Sound Design SOP — The Program

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1. Purpose and scope

Every piece The Program ships gets a score built from key-locked tonal elements, not a playlist of licensed songs. The producer makes the musical and emotional decisions; the library supplies the parts.

Applies to: long-form video, podcast video cuts, branded stories and sponsor reads produced by The Program.

Owner: Audio Producer. **Reviewed by:** Producer/Director before picture lock.

Why we work this way

- **Story leads, music follows.** A song arrives with its own shape (intro, verse, chorus, bridge). Our edits don't share that shape, so songs drag the cut somewhere it didn't ask to go.
- **One key, one world.** When every cue lives in the same key, cues can stack, overlap and hand off without clashes. A whole film sounds like one composed piece.
- **Fewer licences, less risk.** The benchmark film below used one licensed track in 18 minutes, and only for the sponsor segment.
- **Silence is a tool.** Music drops out on purpose so the listener's ears reset and the next cue lands harder.

2. The toolkit

Tonal sound effects are musical building blocks that come in all 12 keys. They are neither sound effects (noise like whooshes and booms) nor songs (a finished emotional arc). Treat them like Lego: stack layers in one key to build a score.

Element	What it does	When to reach for it
Story loop	Holds one emotion for 16 bars, loopable	The bed under a section or argument
Texture / drone	Sustained pad or string field underneath	Add depth or tension without new melody

Element	What it does	When to reach for it
Tonal riser	Builds tension into a moment, in key	Leading into a punchline or reveal
Tonal transition	Bridges one cue or scene into the next	Section changes, cut points
Tonal hit	A single pitched accent	Landing a name, number or key word
Melody	A short tonal line	Signal a turn, a disaster, a new idea
Chord progression	Harmonic movement over a bed	Lift a section emotionally
Licensed song	A complete track	Sponsor reads or moments outside the story

Story loop anatomy

1. 16 bars total, one emotion the whole way (curiosity, questioning, momentum, melancholy).
2. Bars 1–8: one element only. Keep it sparse.
3. Bars 9–16: add one small layer to keep the listener leaning in. Nothing dramatic.
4. Loop again as many times as the scene needs. The loop holds the feeling; the edit decides how long.

Loops are catalogued by emotion name. Pick the loop by the feeling of the scene, not by genre.

3. Pre-production: map before you score

No cue goes on the timeline until the emotional map is done. Work from the locked script or a transcript of the assembly.

1. **Break the piece into sections.** Mark every change of topic, speaker, or voice (VO vs interview).
2. **Name one emotion per section.** Use the library's loop names: curious, questioning, momentum, threat, sad, melancholy.
3. **Flag the payoff lines.** Find the lines the edit builds toward. These get risers and hits.

4. **Flag the silences.** Pick 2–3 places where music drops out entirely (a hard image, a heavy fact, a breath before a turn).
5. **Choose a home key.** One minor key for the whole piece (the benchmark used A minor).
6. **Choose a contrast key.** One related key for a perspective shift (the benchmark used D minor, then returned home).
7. **Mark non-story segments.** Sponsor reads and ads get a licensed track or a separate bed, then hand back to the score.

Deliverable: a cue map with columns for timecode, section, emotion, key, element type, and notes. Share it with the director before scoring.

4. Scoring workflow

Build the score in layers, bed first, accents last. Each pass has one job.

1. **Cold open.** Start with a tonal riser into a short, rhythmic loop (a ticking clock loop works for urgency), then a tonal transition into the first full story loop.
2. **Lay the beds.** Place one story loop per section from the cue map. Loop it as many times as the section runs (the benchmark looped some loops 2.5–4 times).
3. **Ride the meaning.** When the words describe change, let the music echo it. Example: a loop speeds up as the speaker says the cycle sped up.
4. **Add textures.** Fade a drone or string field under a loop to deepen a moment without adding melody. Keep it in the home key.
5. **Build to the payoff lines.** Stack a riser, a pad and a symbolic loop (a clock for running out of time) under the line the section builds toward.
6. **Place tonal hits.** Land a pitched hit on a key word or name. Bury it low in the mix; it should be felt, not noticed.
7. **Mark turns with melody.** Bring in a short melody over the drone when the story turns (a disaster, a new era).
8. **Shift key for a shift in voice.** Move to the contrast key when a new perspective speaks, then return home when the narrator takes back over.
9. **Lift with chords.** Add a chord progression when a section needs emotional weight.
10. **Cut the music.** Drop all music at the flagged silences. Bring it back with a subtle tonal riser.

11. **Handle sponsor segments.** Use the one licensed track here only, matched to the host's personality. Hand back to the score with a story loop.
12. **Land the ending.** Close on a loop that matches the final feeling (the benchmark ended on "melancholy") and end cleanly with the last line.

5. Mix standards

Dialogue is king; the score supports and never competes. The source film shows accents buried so low they're barely audible, and that's the point.

Layer	Mix rule
Dialogue / VO	Always on top, clear and consistent
Story loop	Sits under dialogue; duck under speech
Texture / drone	Felt more than heard; fade in and out, never cut
Tonal hit / swell	Buried; an accent you'd miss if it were gone
Riser / transition	Subtle; shape the edit, don't announce it
Licensed song	Sponsor segments only; may sit higher

- Fade loops in and out; avoid hard starts unless a cut calls for it.
- Never layer elements from different keys at the same time.
- Check every transition on headphones and laptop speakers.
- Name stems by element type (Dialogue, Loops, Textures, Accents, Licensed) for revisions.

6. Benchmark: Matt D'Avella's consumerism film

An 18-minute documentary on fast fashion, scored almost entirely from tonal elements, as broken down by Multiply Sound (Film Score Collection Vol. 3). Use it as the reference standard.

Element	Count
Story loops	9

Element	Count
Tonal transitions, risers and hits	23
Textures and drones	5
Chord progressions	1
Tonal melodies	1
Licensed songs	1 (sponsor read only)

Cue walkthrough

Section	What happens on screen	Sound design move
Cold open	Host asks where people buy clothes	Tonal riser into clock loop, transition into first story loop
Haul culture	Social media hauls	String-field texture fades in under the loop; buried swell as people enter a room
Payoff line	Host says consumerism has gone too far	Clock bell, risers and a pad build to the line; clock = time running out
Disaster footage	Hard-to-watch images	No music
History	Seasonal clothing, then fast fashion	Drone + melody; next loop speeds up as "sped up" is said
Ultra fast fashion	Zara, Shein named	Buried tonal hit on the brand name; new loop when story shifts
Interview handoff	VO cuts back to interview	Music stops; break, then subtle riser back in
Prices	Price data, inflation	Calmer loop, looped four times
Haul interview	Influencer perspective	Key change to D minor with piano; back to A minor after
Overconsumption	Buying more, keeping less	Chord progression enters
Social media	Meta settlement	Sadder overtone replaces curious loops

Section	What happens on screen	Sound design move
Sponsor	Squarespace read	The one licensed song (jazz), then straight back to score
Supply chain	Who pays the price	"Threat" loop, looped 2.5 times; small riser and hit
Ending	Host's conclusion	"Melancholy" loop; ends cleanly on the last line

7. QC checklist

Tick every box before the mix goes to the director.

- [ ] Cue map shared and approved before scoring
- [ ] Every section has one named emotion and one story loop
- [ ] All elements in the home key, except planned contrast-key moments
- [ ] Contrast key returns home when the perspective returns
- [ ] Payoff lines have a riser or hit building to them
- [ ] At least one intentional music-free break
- [ ] Accents buried under dialogue; nothing distracts from speech
- [ ] Licensed music limited to sponsor or non-story segments
- [ ] Ending loop matches the final emotion and ends on the last line
- [ ] Checked on headphones and laptop speakers
- [ ] Stems named and exported by element type

The rule of thumb: if a cue doesn't reflect what's being said, cut it.